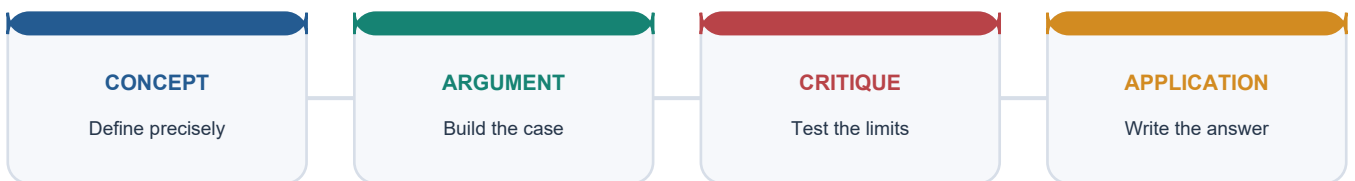


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Theatre, Puppetry and Performance Traditions - Solved Practice Workbook

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Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

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Theatre, Puppetry and Performance Traditions - Solved Practice Workbook

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BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

CORE UPSC MCQS

Q1. Which statement about Indian theatre's foundational grammar is safest?

A. Natya Shastra is best treated as a composite dramaturgic framework joining text, enactment, music and rasa. B. Natya Shastra should be defined only as a manual for later dance schools. C. Natya Shastra is identical with the modern National School of Drama curriculum. D. Natya Shastra proves that every later theatre form remained unchanged across centuries.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because the source-owned bank presents Natya Veda as a composite performance system. B narrows theatre into dance alone, C confuses an ancient dramaturgic text with a modern institution, and D turns a layered textual tradition into an unsound continuity claim.

Q2. Which pair is correctly matched?

A. Lokadharmi - wholly symbolic and stylised narration B. Natyadharmi - conventional, stylised and symbolic narration C. Lokadharmi - only temple ritual without dramatic representation D. Natyadharmi - modern ticketed proscenium theatre

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. Lokadharmi refers to realistic depiction of life, whereas Natyadharmi denotes stylised, conventional narration. A reverses the pair, C invents a ritual restriction, and D confuses an ancient dramaturgic mode with a modern theatre economy.

Q3. Which option correctly preserves the source-owned ten-rupaka list?

A. Nataka, Prakarana, Vilasa, Vithi, Rasaka, Uparupaka, Bhana, Natika, Chitra and Kavya B. Nataka, Prakarana, Bhana, Prahasana, Dima, Vyayoga, Samavakara, Vithi, Natyam and Utsava C. Nataka, Prakarana, Bhana, Prahasana, Dima, Vyayoga, Samavakara, Vithi, Ihamriga and Utsrishtikanka D. Nataka, Rupaka, Vidushaka, Nayaka, Nayika, Vithi, Dima, Samavakara, Geet and Nritya

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because it preserves the list carried in the topic bank. A and B insert forms not given there, while D mixes genre terms with stage roles and generic performance words.

Q4. Which statement about the Sutradhar is correct?

A. The Sutradhar is merely the hero's comic companion. B. The Sutradhar is only the puppeteer's string and never a theatre figure. C. The Sutradhar is the title of every Sanskrit play. D. The Sutradhar conducts the opening threshold of the play and in puppetry the term can also evoke the holder of strings.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct. A describes the Vidusaka, B erases the classical stage role, and C confuses a functionary with the title of a play.

Q5. Which statement about character and language register in Sanskrit theatre is safest?

A. The Vidusaka is a comic-satirical figure who traditionally speaks Prakrit while others use Sanskrit. B. The Nayika is the stage manager who announces time and place. C. The Nayaka is the leather shadow puppet projected against a lit screen. D. Language register has no role in classical theatre according to the source bank.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct. B confuses Nayika with Sutradhar, C confuses a character category with puppetry, and D ignores the explicit Vidusaka/Prakrit clue.

Q6. Which statement about Sanskrit play conventions is safest?

A. All Sanskrit plays were historical chronicles without codified dramatic structure. B. The source records multi-act plays, rare tragedy, ordered dramatic progression and endings that restore success or order. C. Masks were always mandatory in Bharata's stage prescription. D. The stage had no ritual opening or framed entry.

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct because it summarises the recorded conventions. A ignores dramaturgic codification, C reverses the source note that masks were not used in Bharata's prescription, and D erases the ritualised opening with the Sutradhar.

Q7. Which statement about Sitabenga and Jogimara is safest for UPSC use?

A. They prove beyond dispute the exact architectural form of every ancient Sanskrit theatre. B. They are irrelevant because archaeology can never speak to performance history. C. They are linked by some scholars to performance, but the popular 'world's oldest amphitheatre' claim should remain qualified, not asserted as settled fact. D. They are the same as the Kerala koothambalam tradition.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because it preserves the evidentiary limit. A overclaims, B swings to an opposite absolute, and D collapses unrelated performance contexts.

Q8. Which statement best identifies Kutiyattam?

A. It is a Marathi commercial theatre of the Parsi era. B. It is an Assamese one-act Vaishnavite play of Sankardeva's school. C. It is a Gujarati pot-balancing folk theatre performed by the Nayaka. D. It is a living Kerala Sanskrit-theatre lineage marked by multilingual performance, Nirvahana and instruments such as Mizhavu and Edakka.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct. A points to modern western-Indian commercial theatre, B to Ankia Naat/Bhaona, and C to Bhavai.

Q9. Which statement about the official UNESCO route for Kutiyattam is safest?

A. UNESCO describes it as one of India's oldest living theatrical traditions and records its inscription in 2008 on the Representative List. B. UNESCO treats it as proof that all Sanskrit theatre everywhere survives unchanged. C. UNESCO uses Kutiyattam to create the ten-rupaka list. D. UNESCO classifies it as a puppetry mechanism rather than theatre.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct and keeps the official page within bounds. B invents a continuity claim, C confuses inscription with dramaturgic theory, and D misclassifies the form entirely.

Q10. Which sequence best captures the core folk-theatre arc in the source bank?

A. Court tragedy -> museum display -> digital cinema B. Devotional themes -> romance/local heroes -> social messages alongside entertainment C. Ancient republic drama -> colonial bureaucracy -> postmodern absurdism D. Only martial training -> only temple ritual -> only tourism

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct because it follows the source-owned developmental arc. The other options invent trajectories that are not the topic's teaching spine.

Q11. Which pair is correctly matched?

A. Yakshagana - a rod-puppet form of Bihar B. Nautanki - a Kerala temple shadow theatre using oil lamps C. Bhavai - a Gujarat folk theatre in which dance, semi-classical folk music and balancing vessels are major identifiers D. Jatra - a glove-puppet form of Rajasthan

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct. A confuses Yakshagana with rod puppetry, B mixes Nautanki with Tolpava Kuthu, and D misclassifies Jatra as puppetry.

Q12. Which statement should be avoided in a theatre answer?

A. Many folk theatres are rooted in locality, belief and custom. B. Some current region labels are modern locators rather than ancient state proofs. C. Folk theatre can carry devotional, romantic and social-message layers across time. D. All folk theatre forms may safely be treated as unchanged ancient survivals with fixed modern-state identities.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is the unsafe statement because it collapses historical change and overprojects modern geography backwards. A, B and C are the safe analytical controls provided by the topic spine.

Q13. Which statement about modern Indian theatre is correct?

A. It grew in the colonial era as an urban hybrid influenced by Sanskrit and Western texts, especially in proscenium-style centres such as Calcutta and Madras. B. It emerged only after 1947 and had no colonial background. C. It developed only in temples and never on commercial stages. D. It rejected social and political themes throughout the colonial period.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because it captures the colonial-urban hybrid character of modern theatre. B, C and D contradict the source bank's account of commercial stages and politically sensitive themes.

Q14. Which statement about Parsi theatre is safest?

A. It belonged only to Assam's Vaishnavite monastery culture. B. It flourished in western India from the 1850s to the 1920s, used colourful backdrops and music, and later fed into film-making. C. It was the ancient Sanskrit stage described by Bharata. D. It is another name for Bhavai's Nayaka-led folk theatre.

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. A confuses it with Assamese devotional theatre, C with classical Sanskrit dramaturgy, and D with Gujarati folk theatre.

Q15. What is the safest significance of the Dramatic Performances Act, 1876 in this topic?

A. It created the ten rupakas of Bharata. B. It nationalised all folk theatre troupes. C. It shows that theatre had become politically consequential enough for colonial regulation. D. It marks UNESCO's inscription of Kutiyattam.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct. A and D confuse unrelated chronology, while B is a fabricated policy claim.

Q16. Which statement about post-Independence theatre organisation is correct?

A. IPTA was a medieval Vaishnavite theatre school. B. Prithvi Theatre began as a temple stage in Odisha. C. The National School of Drama was the first Sanskrit theatre described by Bharata. D. IPTA organised socially engaged theatre, Prithvi used a touring model, and institutions such as SNA and NSD helped consolidate theatre training after Independence.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct because it distinguishes three modern nodes properly. A, B and C each misplace a modern institution into an unrelated historical field.

Q17. Which statement about Binodini Dasi is safest?

A. She is a high-value example for Bengali theatre professionalism, the Star Theatre story and women's visibility on the modern stage. B. She was the author of Natya Shastra. C. She founded the Sangeet Natak Akademi in 1952. D. She was the principal puppeteer of Kathputli in Rajasthan.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct. B, C and D attribute unrelated roles and institutions to Binodini Dasi.

Q18. Which statement correctly identifies Badal Sircar's contribution?

A. He created the leather shadow puppets of Ravana Chhaya. B. He pioneered Third Theatre: small, experimental, socially conscious performance with minimalist staging and direct actor-audience interaction. C. He led the Chakraborty-Nambiar Kutiyattam lineage in Kerala. D. He founded the Calcutta Theatre in 1775.

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. A belongs to shadow puppetry, C to Kutiyattam's hereditary performance world, and D to a much earlier venue chronology.

Q19. Which classification best organises Indian puppetry?

A. Temple, court, marketplace and cinema B. Heroic, romantic, satirical and tragic C. String, shadow, rod and glove D. Sanskrit, Prakrit, Brajvali and Malayalam

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because mechanism is the formal classificatory basis used in the source. The other options sort by venue, theme or language rather than puppet control.

Q20. Which regional-mechanism match is correct?

A. Kundhei - glove puppetry of Kerala B. Pavakoothu - shadow puppetry of Odisha C. Ravana Chhaya - rod puppetry of Bihar D. Kathputli - string puppetry of Rajasthan using legless dolls controlled by strings tied to the fingers

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct. Kundhei is a string tradition of Odisha, Pavakoothu is a glove tradition of Kerala, and Ravana Chhaya is shadow puppetry of Odisha rather than rod puppetry of Bihar.

Q21. Which statement about shadow puppetry is correct?

A. Shadow puppets are flat leather or opaque figures projected on a lit screen to create silhouettes. B. Shadow puppets are always carved from a single block of wood and manipulated by waist rods. C. Shadow puppets are necessarily legless marionettes controlled only by fingers. D. Shadow puppetry has no role for light or screen.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because light-screen projection is the defining mechanism. B describes a rod-puppet tendency, C string puppetry, and D erases the core technical basis of shadow theatre.

Q22. Which statement about rod, glove and hybrid puppetry is safest?

A. Putul Nach is the Kerala glove tradition shaped by Kathakali. B. Pavakoothu is the classic glove example, rod traditions such as Yampuri or Putul Nach scale the figure up, and Bommalattam is a useful hybrid caution because it mixes rod and string control. C. All rod and glove forms are too small to need accompaniment or narration. D. Bommalattam proves that the four basic mechanisms are false and meaningless.

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. A confuses Putul Nach with Pavakoothu, C ignores performance ecology, and D mistakes a hybrid exception for the collapse of the main classification.

Q23. Which statement best captures puppetry as archive?

A. Puppetry matters only as low-cost amusement with no intellectual or cultural transmission value. B. Puppetry can be explained without reference to mechanism, narration or regional ecology. C. Puppetry's links to epic references, Silappadikaram, the Bhagavad Gita's puppeteer metaphor and the Sutradhar idea let it be read as a transmission medium as well as performance. D. Puppetry is a modern invention of film-era children's culture.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because it keeps the topic's deeper interpretive value. A and D trivialise the form, while B removes the very features that make classification and interpretation possible.

Q24. Which statement about the present condition of puppetry is safest?

A. The source treats puppetry as a fully secure art with no present challenges. B. The only valid response to puppetry is museum preservation because it is no longer performed. C. Puppetry's difficulties are identical to the historical decline of Sanskrit theatre. D. The source explicitly notes an ongoing funding-and-audience crisis in puppetry and therefore points toward living safeguarding, with Anupama Hoskere/Dhaatu as a named revival example.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct because it preserves the present-tense vulnerability and the named revival example. A denies the source, B erases living practice, and C confuses two different decline types.

Q25. Which statement about Kalaripayattu is correct?

A. It is a martial tradition associated especially with Kerala, marked by footwork, mock duels and a training-space logic implied by the word kalari. B. It is a Vaishnavite shadow-puppet performance of coastal Karnataka. C. It is a Gujarati folk theatre built around pot-balancing. D. It is the same as the Prakrit-speaking Vidusaka role in Sanskrit theatre.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct. B confuses it with folk or puppetry forms, C with Bhavai, and D with a classical stage role.

Q26. Which statement correctly matches martial-performance traditions?

A. Gatka belongs to the Chakyar temple-theatre lineage of Kerala. B. Thang-ta is a Meitei martial tradition of Manipur centred on sword and spear, while Pari-khanda is associated with sword-and-shield practice in Bihar and has links to Chhau movement vocabulary. C. Silambam is a rod-puppet form of eastern India. D. Pari-khanda is a Marathi commercial theatre founded in 1944.

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct because it preserves region and weapon logic. A misplaces Gatka, C confuses martial art with puppetry, and D turns a martial practice into a modern theatre company.

Q27. Which statement best captures the ritual-devotional-public performance ecology of this topic?

A. All performance traditions in Topic 10 are reducible to dance grammar and should be answered under Topic 09. B. Any form with musical accompaniment automatically belongs to Topic 08 instead of theatre. C. Forms may be ritual, devotional, satirical, martial or public-entertainment oriented; the safest answer identifies the dominant ecology before discussing borrowed movement or music. D. Only Sanskrit theatre deserves analytical treatment; folk and ritual forms are too mixed to classify.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because it provides the topic's functional classification rule. A and B erase ownership boundaries, while D ignores the whole folk-performance bank.

Q28. Which statement should be avoided in a question on martial or ritual performance?

A. A form may shift between combat training and choreographed public display. B. Weapon, pedagogy and occasion are better discriminators than generic antiquity claims. C. Borrowing movement from dance does not automatically convert a martial performance into a classical dance form. D. Every martial or ritual performance may be written as the same timeless, unchanging ancient Indian art without separate regional grammar.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is the unsafe statement because it destroys regional and functional specificity. A, B and C are the safe control lines for this mixed performance field.

Q29. Which boundary statement is safest?

A. Topic 10 owns dramatic composition, stage relation and puppet mechanism, while music systems, dance grammar, literary history and the full UNESCO/SNA ledgers belong elsewhere. B. Topic 10 should retell the whole history of raga and tala because theatre uses music. C. Topic 10 must absorb every classical-dance technical question because some theatre forms use gesture. D. Topic 10 is identical with Topic 11 because plays are written texts.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because it preserves syllabus ownership and prevents duplication. B, C and D each erase necessary boundaries with Music, Dance or Literature.

Q30. Which modern-theatre sequence is correctly ordered in broad terms?

A. NSD independence -> Natya Shastra -> Calcutta Theatre -> Parsi theatre B. Colonial urban proscenium -> commercial stage and censorship -> political and touring theatre -> post-Independence institutional consolidation C. UNESCO inscription -> ten rupakas -> Bhakti-era Jatra -> Chakyar temple theatre D. Puppetry decline -> Harappan origin -> Third Theatre -> Sanskrit stage

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct because it follows the topic's actual chronology. The other options scramble chronology or merge unrelated subfields.

Q31. Which concluding statement about decline and safeguarding is safest?

A. Sanskrit theatre and puppetry represent exactly the same kind of decline and therefore need the same answer. B. Kutiyattam proves that no historical contraction of Sanskrit theatre ever took place. C. The topic is analytically strongest when it separates the historical contraction of Sanskrit theatre from the ongoing audience-and-livelihood vulnerability of living puppetry and related performance traditions. D. Once a form is old, safeguarding becomes irrelevant because age guarantees continuity.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because it preserves the advanced distinction between completed historical contraction and ongoing living vulnerability. A, B and D each flatten a key analytical difference.

Q32. Which final statement should be avoided?

A. Use one discriminating feature to identify each theatre or puppetry form. B. Keep present state labels as reference tools rather than ancient political certainties. C. Treat living traditions as performance ecologies involving artists, audiences and institutions. D. All folk, puppet and performance traditions may be safely reduced to colourful leftovers once Sanskrit theatre declined.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is the false and unsafe conclusion because it trivialises living traditions and destroys the topic's analytical structure. A, B and C are safe closing controls.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED OBJECTIVE / APPLICATION PYQS

PYQ 1. Which of the following statements about Binodini Dasi, a pioneering figure in Bengali theatre, in the late 19th and early 20th century is/are correct? 1. She was one of the prime movers behind the setting up of the Star Theatre (1883) in Calcutta. 2. She serialised her autobiography Amar Katha (My story) between 1910 and 1913. Select the correct answer using the code given below: (CAPF, 2018)

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key

Concept route: The topic bank and Nitin clearly support Statement 1: Binodini Dasi contributed to founding the Star Theatre in Kolkata in 1883. The same source confirms that Amar Katha was published in 1913, but it does not independently verify the paper's precise serialisation wording used in Statement 2. Because no final official or local-official answer key for this exact UPSC objective item was independently verified in-session, the answer letter is withheld even though the conceptual route is recoverable.

PYQ 2. With reference to India's culture and tradition, what is 'Kalaripayattu'? (CSE, 2014) (a) It is an ancient Bhakti cult of Shaivism still prevalent in some parts of South India. (b) It is an ancient style bronze and brass work still found in Southern part of Coromandel area. (c) It is an ancient form of dance, drama and a living tradition in the Northern part of Malabar. (d) It is an ancient martial art and a living tradition in some parts of South India.

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key

Concept route: The conceptual elimination route is strong: Kalaripayattu belongs to the martial-performance field, especially Kerala and wider southern India, and not to a Bhakti cult, metal craft or a dance-drama label. However, because no final official or local-official key for the 2014 objective was independently verified inside the approved local key bank used in this repair session, the letter is withheld and only the concept route is printed.

DIRECT SOLVED MAINS PYQS

PYQ-M1. Write a sentence each on any five of the following traditional theatre forms: (a) Bhand Pather (b) Swang (c) Maach (d) Bhaona (e) Mudi yettu (f) Dashavatar. (CSE, 2011)

Examiner-ready response bank:

- **Bhand Pather** is the secular, satirical folk theatre of Jammu and Kashmir, performed by Muslims and combining music, dance and social critique.
- **Swang / Saang** is a musical-drama tradition of the Rajasthan-Haryana-Malwa belt, using verse, mimicry and instruments such as ektara, harmonium, sarangi, dholak and khartal.
- **Maach** is the Malwa folk theatre of Madhya Pradesh, first centred on mythological themes and later widened to romantic tales, with dialogues often delivered as **Rangat Dohas**.
- **Bhaona** is the Assamese performance presentation of the Vaishnavite dramatic world of Sankardeva, using Sutradhar narration, songs, music and moral-religious themes.
- **Mudi yettu** is a Kerala ritual theatre linked to goddess-centred sacred performance and should be written as ritual performance rather than as a generic folk-dance label.
- **Dashavatar** is the Konkani folk-theatre form of Maharashtra-Goa honouring Vishnu's ten incarnations, structured through poorva-ranga and utara-ranga segments.

PYQ-M2. Write about Yakshagana. (CSE, 1995, 2005, 2007)

Introduction: Yakshagana is one of the strongest examples of regional Indian theatre because it combines narration, costume, music, movement and devotional storytelling without fitting neatly into only 'dance' or only 'drama'.

Body: The source-owned bank places Yakshagana in Karnataka and parts of Kerala and links its origin memory to the Vijayanagara court world. It was associated with a performing community called **Jakkula Varu** and later developed into a fuller dance-drama tradition under strong **Vaishnava Bhakti** influence. Its importance for answer-writing lies in its composite nature: elaborate costume and performance energy matter, but so do narration, theme and musical support. It also becomes analytically useful as a cross-link because Karnataka's **Gombeyatta** string puppets borrow their visual design from Yakshagana characters.

Conclusion: Yakshagana should therefore be written as a living regional theatre grammar - devotional in inheritance, dramatic in staging and influential beyond its own form.

PYQ-M3. Where did the following traditional folk theatres originate? (a) Jatra (b) Tamasha (c) Koodiyattam (d) Bhavai (e) Nautanki (CSE, 1987)

Form	Origin / regional field	One safe identifier
Jatra	Bengal / eastern India	Open-air theatre associated initially with Chaitanya's Krishna-propagation route
Tamasha	Maharashtra	Folk theatre with humour, erotic charge and Lavani accompaniment
Koodiyattam / Kutiyattam	Kerala	Living Sanskrit-theatre lineage using Nirvahana and instruments like Mizhavu
Bhavai	Gujarat	Dance-rich folk theatre with balancing vessels and Nayaka as the Sutradhar term
Nautanki	North India	Lyrical theatre, an offshoot of Swang, often accompanied by Nagada

PYQ-M4. What efforts have been made to develop theatre in India? Name any two important persons associated with the development of this art. (CSE, 1985)

Introduction: Theatre in modern India developed through a mix of city stages, travelling companies, political collectives and post-Independence institutions rather than through one single reform moment.

Body: In the colonial era, proscenium-style urban theatre grew in centres such as Calcutta and Madras, while commercial stages widened audiences and themes. The **Dramatic Performances Act, 1876** ironically proves the political force of theatre because the colonial state felt the need to regulate it. **Parsi theatre** expanded spectacle, music and commercial organisation, then passed talent and style into film. In the twentieth century, the **Indian People's Theatre Association (1943)** used theatre for mass social intervention; **Prithvi Theatre (1944)** used mobility as a distribution strategy; and after Independence institutions such as the **Sangeet Natak Akademi (1952)** and the **National School of Drama** helped training, repertory and public legitimacy. Regional initiatives such as **Kalakshetra Manipur** and **NINASAM** deepened the field beyond metropolitan centres.

Two important persons may be named from different moments: **Binodini Dasi**, for Bengali stage professionalism and the Star Theatre story, and **Badal Sircar**, for Third Theatre's socially conscious minimalist intervention.

Conclusion: Development of Indian theatre was therefore institutional, public and regional - not merely literary.

ORIGINAL MAINS ANSWERS

Original Q1. Explain why Natya Shastra vocabulary is indispensable for answering questions on Indian theatre. (10 marks, 150 words)

Indian theatre becomes answerable only when its technical vocabulary is kept exact. Natya Shastra frames performance as composite art, so the candidate can write theatre as text plus enactment plus music plus rasa instead of as literature alone. The Lokadharmi-Natyadharmi distinction then separates realistic depiction from stylised convention. The ten rupakas show genre classification, while the Sutradhar explains how the play is ritually and performatively introduced. Character categories such as Nayaka, Nayika and Vidusaka add the stage-social dimension, and the Vidusaka's Prakrit preserves a language-register clue. This vocabulary matters because UPSC frequently asks culture questions through close options where all terms are real but only one is accurately used. Without terminological precision, the answer collapses into ornamental generalisation rather than dramaturgic analysis.

Original Q2. Why should Kutiyattam be used to qualify, rather than erase, the decline of Sanskrit theatre? (10 marks, 150 words)

Kutiyattam is crucial because it proves survival of a lineage without cancelling the historical contraction of the broader Sanskrit-theatre world. The source records real decline mechanisms for Sanskrit drama: writers moved to poems and songs, difficult Sanskrit lost reach, and patronage shifted. Yet Kutiyattam in Kerala preserved a living performance line through multilingual enactment, Nirvahana, Mizhavu-Edakka accompaniment and hereditary training. UNESCO's official page reinforces this by describing it as one of India's oldest living theatrical traditions and a synthesis of Sanskrit classicism with local Kerala practice. Therefore the best answer is balanced: Sanskrit theatre did decline as a large civilisational stage system, but it did not vanish without residue. Kutiyattam is not evidence of unchanged continuity everywhere; it is evidence of a durable regional survival mechanism.

Original Q3. Compare Jatra, Nautanki, Tamasha and Bhavai as public theatres. (15 marks, 250 words)

Introduction: Regional public theatres in India are best compared through audience relation, musical delivery, thematic field and stage marker rather than through a simple folk-versus-classical divide.

Body: **Jatra** belongs to the eastern/Bengal field and is structurally memorable as an open-air theatre. It begins from Chaitanya's Krishna-propagation route and later broadens to secular, historical and patriotic themes. **Nautanki** is the north Indian offshoot of Swang and is recognised by lyrical dialogue delivery with **Nagada** accompaniment; its later Kanpur and Lucknow schools show internal differentiation. **Tamasha** of Maharashtra is marked by humour, erotic charge and **Lavani** linkage, with the striking feature that women may play male roles. **Bhavai** of Gujarat combines dance with a series of smaller plays, uses semi-classical folk music and remembers its Sutradhar as the **Nayaka**; balancing earthen pots or brass pitchers becomes a crisp identifier.

Analysis: All four forms are public and performative, but their publics are organised differently: Jatra through open-air collective circulation, Nautanki through lyrical theatre, Tamasha through performative charisma and Bhavai through dance-rich episodic staging.

Conclusion: A good answer therefore distinguishes them through their discriminating marker instead of calling all of them simply 'popular folk drama'.

Original Q4. Classify Indian puppetry and explain why mechanism-region matching matters. (15 marks, 250 words)

Introduction: Indian puppetry is one of the clearest art-form topics where classification directly decides accuracy. Mechanism comes before regional example.

Body: The source classifies puppetry into **string, shadow, rod and glove** forms. String puppets include **Kathputli** of Rajasthan, known for legless wooden dolls controlled by finger-tied strings; **Kundhei** of Odisha, with more joints and marked Odissi influence; and **Gombeyatta** of Karnataka, designed after Yakshagana characters and sometimes using more than one puppeteer. Shadow puppetry includes **Tolpava Kuthu** of Kerala, **Ravana Chhaya** of Odisha and **Tholu Bommalata** of Andhra Pradesh; here screen, light and silhouette are decisive. Rod forms include **Yampuri**, **Putul Nach** and **Kathi Kundhei**, while **Pavakoothu** exemplifies glove puppetry.

Analysis: Mechanism-region matching matters because close-option prelims often present only one altered clue. If Tholu Bommalata is mislabelled as string instead of shadow, or Pavakoothu is confused with Tolpava Kuthu, the entire answer collapses. Mechanism also reveals performance ecology - scale, narration, portability and audience relation.

Conclusion: Indian puppetry should therefore be remembered as control-system plus region plus one visual discriminator, not as a flat list of names.

Original Q5. Trace the trajectory of Indian theatre from the Sanskrit stage to modern institutional and street theatre. (20 marks, 250 words)

Introduction: The history of Indian theatre is not a straight line from 'classical' to 'modern'; it is a sequence of changing publics, languages, institutions and performance economies.

Body: The classical point of departure is the *Natya Shastra*, which codifies dramaturgy, stage roles, language register and dramatic conventions. Sanskrit theatre records multi-act structure, ordered progression, rare tragedy and Sutracharya-led beginnings. Its contraction followed literary shift, linguistic difficulty and changed patronage, yet survival was not extinguished because **Kutiyattam** in Kerala preserved a living Sanskrit-theatre lineage. Alongside and after this contraction, regional **folk theatres** developed strong local ecologies: devotional origins, later heroic and romantic expansion, and eventually social communication roles. The colonial city then transformed theatre again. **Calcutta Theatre (1775)**, proscenium architecture, commercial stages and the **Dramatic Performances Act (1876)** mark a new public sphere. **Parsi theatre** created a colourful commercial mass stage and bridged towards cinema. In the twentieth century, **Tagore**, **Binodini Dasi**, **IPTA (1943)**, **Prithvi Theatre (1944)** and later **Badal Sircar's Third Theatre** widened the range from literary-nationalist to political to minimalist-direct theatre. After Independence, **Sangeet Natak Akademi** and **National School of Drama** consolidated training and legitimacy, while **NINASAM**, **Kalakshetra Manipur** and similar bodies regionalised modern renewal.

Conclusion: Indian theatre thus moves from codified dramaturgy to regional public performance to colonial-commercial hybridity and finally to institutional, travelling and experimental modern publics.

Original Q6. 'Living performance traditions require audiences as much as archives.' Discuss with reference to puppetry and folk theatre. (20 marks, 250 words)

Introduction: Heritage survives differently depending on whether the form is already a historical residue or still a living public art. Puppetry and folk theatre prove this distinction.

Body: Folk theatre and puppetry are not merely texts or artefacts; they are audience-dependent ecologies. The folk-theatre bank shows forms rooted in locality, belief and custom, many of which moved from devotional themes to heroic/romantic and then social-message roles. Their continued survival depends on performative relevance to the public. Puppetry makes the point even more sharply. The source presents it as a composite art that incorporates theatre, music, dance, sculpture and painting, and also as an archive of mythic and philosophical transmission through epic references and the puppeteer metaphor. Yet the same source explicitly states that puppetry is currently declining because of lack of funding and captive audience. That is why revival efforts such as **Anupama Hoskote's Dhaatu** matter: they are not merely preserving objects but sustaining performers, repertoires and publics.

Analysis: Archives and documentation are vital, especially for historically contracted traditions, but a living form cannot be reduced to storage. Audience circulation, training, staging and community context are part of the heritage itself.

Conclusion: Therefore, the strongest safeguarding line in this topic is not 'preserve the old art' but 'keep the old art performable before living publics'.